

India's nuclear weapons program.

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India's Nuclear Weapons Program

Historical Milestones

1974 - Smiling Buddha Test

- India conducted its first nuclear test, becoming the sixth nuclear-armed nation
- Positioned as a "peaceful nuclear explosion" rather than a weapons test
- Marked India's entry into the nuclear club outside the original five permanent UN Security Council members

1998 - Pokharan II Tests

- Series of five nuclear tests conducted, establishing India as an overt nuclear weapons state
- Demonstrated thermonuclear and fission capabilities
- Led to international sanctions and shifted India's nuclear status from ambiguous to declared

Post-1998 Development

- Establishment of formal nuclear command authority and doctrine
- Development of ballistic missile delivery systems (Agni series)
- Expansion of submarine-based deterrence capabilities
- Estimated current arsenal: 160+ warheads

Nuclear Doctrine & Regional Comparison

India's Distinctive Approach:

- **No First Use (NFU) Policy:** Commits to using nuclear weapons only in retaliation against nuclear attacks
- **Credible Minimum Deterrence:** Maintains sufficient arsenal for second-strike capability without pursuing parity with larger arsenals
- Contrasts sharply with Pakistan's "First Use" doctrine and China's more ambiguous posture

Regional Security Implications:

- Creates strategic stability framework based on deterrence rather than escalation
- Positions India as a responsible nuclear power emphasizing restraint
- NFU policy reduces risks of accidental escalation during conventional conflicts

- Enables India to maintain credible defense posture against two nuclear-armed neighbors

Key Differences from Other Nuclear Powers:

- More transparent doctrinal framework than China
- Less aggressive stance than Pakistan's first-use policy
- Emphasizes civilian control and democratic oversight
- Committed to nuclear nonproliferation while maintaining deterrence

Current Status

India's nuclear program balances security imperatives with nonproliferation commitments. The combination of NFU doctrine, minimum deterrence, and advanced delivery systems creates a stabilizing effect in South Asia, though regional tensions periodically test the doctrine's resilience.